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From the Editor in Chief's desk:

By Swami ParanandTirth

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and

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The cult of simultaneous transcendence .

Both notions of existent and non existent are relative and complimentary .They can never be successive since neither can be related as cause and effect. In existence, from existence is as much inconsistent as its opposite . An aspirant

after emancipation need not go into the details of their order of succession and instead focus on their concomitant transcendence . There are two inevitable prerequisites, the enlightened preceptor and secondly a competent aspirant . Any adherence to any motion of presupposition and preconception says Kshemraj in his commentary on Pratyabhijna Hridayam , is a

peg to which an aspirant is tied and thus restricted to delve deep in the ocean of pure consciousness .This is being in the conditioned worldly existence, he says.

Except the path of “mahasahasa “a courageous leap into the realm of the absolute and out of the grip of myriad reciprocation of conditioned existence; no upaya or means can lead to the ultimate. Unlike a Vedantist who would establish that without an intuitive insight into the purport of the revelations nescience can not be dispelled and all other means must conduce to this and never lead to the ultimate directly, Tantric canons give us hundreds of such direct means. The post Shankarite vedantists maintain that any method that leads to the recognition of the self should be considered as authentic provided it doesn't conflict any dictum of the Vedas . No such vindication is required says the agamas since there is no one who doesn't have a soul to know himself hence no authority of the Vedas and for that matter any other testimony of evidence is necessary . In the tantric canons like Vijnana Bhairav etc the multiplicity of so many means and upayas are vindicated so as to suit the competence and temperament of aspirants . There is no one who is incompetent to know his self proclaims the Tantra .This great adherence of the monistic commitment which delivers from great fears ,dawns upon two or three aspirants only says a book on monism named Avadhoot Geeta .

Sidhas and yoginis are conventionally the gaggle of male and female ascetics . An arcane sect of “mystic heretics “exempted themselves from the Hermeneutic discipline of faith countenance, poverty and obedience . Some of them did so because owing to their spiritual advancement no such subservience to any monastic governance was needed. The rest rather followed the path of their apparently

deviant preceptors than the cloister -governance from which they deviated .A voyager on the path leading beyond the three gunas is not bound by any rules and injunctions

.(निस्त्रैगुण्येपथिविचरतांकोविधिकोनिषेधः)

Scholars and Mystics like VatulNath and his commentator Anant Shakti employed this semiotics to convey the lofty but mystic axioms of the tantric school , firstly to establish that an aspirant of the agamic path doesn't have to stop at these corporal restrictions and secondly that esoterically the amorous analogies resorted to in these sutras are more conveying than the terse discursive exposition . The union of sidhas and yoginis has nothing amorous or romantic in it. It is simply the unison of sense perceptions and the senses

इन्द्रियैःरूपग्रहणयोग्यताअस्त्वितिआवाहनम्
(Bhvanopanishat)

A clear perception by all senses lead to their source, the subjective awareness without any impediment . Both objective and objective experiences are relative and interdependent so their successive transcendence is not consistent since an aspirant is required to transcend both . All upayas lead you upto the spring board and hurl into the realm of the absolute I.e.pure subjective consciousness unalloyed by any taint of objectivity!

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Editorial



Dr. Geetika Kaw Kher

An individual is caught in the web of multiple objectivity since his birth. Gradually as the soul loses touch with it's 'svarupa' it loses its spontaneity too. The hesitation, doubt, social and cultural constructs all though claimed to have been formulated for the well being of human beings do enough to bind him for the rest of his life with apparent rules and regulations.

Occasionally an aspirant might be ready to take the great leap, the only way to break this vicious cycle and let the universal truth dawn. This great leap requires one to do away with all the notions by which an individual has lived. It demands nothing short of a total paradigm shift, a completely different way of looking at and understanding the world around. This new vision which can only dawn by grace of almighty or by munificence of a competent guru, often clashes with the usual notions and sometimes is totally opposed to them. Hence one's entire person fights it. It does not fit in one's sense of correctness 'auchitya', it looks and feels wrong and opposite of what should be done. One is scared to venture into the zone of unknown and unfathomable and only praying to the divine mother to bestow us with grace and courage can help an aspirant to continue walking on this path.

Explaining the importance of this leap for the spiritual growth of an aspirant in the Editorial

our Guru maharaj, Swami Paranand Tirthji writes, "Except the path of 'mahasahasana' a courageous leap into the realm of the absolute and out of the grip of myriad reciprocation of conditioned existence no upaya or means can lead to the ultimate". Unless one is able to develop this parallel mode of understanding reality, the 'poison of samsara' as Kshemraj calls it, will keep pulling us back into the cycle of births and rebirths.

Next we have Swamiji's enlightening article 'Wisdom from Shiva's Rattle drum' dealing with 'The order of universal manifestation'.

In this article Swamiji talks about the Absolute and his deliberate conditioning and the reasoning of seers of antiquity who taught that the condensation of consciousness as grosser manifestation from ether to the grossest earth is a process that can be learnt only from the revelations. It's metaphysical significance is coded in Shiva's seventh beat of his rattle drum which Swamiji has explained in detail.

This is followed by Dr. Toshkani's erudite article on 'Kashmir's Cultural Affinities with Himalayan Regions'. The case for viewing Kashmir in the perspective of Himalayan culture is indeed very strong feels the author. Moreover he laments the total neglect of this aspect in serious research and believes that venturing into it can lead us to amazing facts about Kashmir's indigenous belief systems, religious expressions, life-patterns and ritualistic behaviour, philosophy, traditional arts and artistic skills, language and literary traditions, folklore, folk-religious beliefs and practices including demonology and animistic and pantheistic worship, oral and intangible heritage, eco-cultural systems and social structure.."

Next we have a thought provoking and a thorough write-up on 'Spanda: signature of Existence' by Niraj Kumar. Idea of 'spanda' the author believes "is at the heart of the remarkable doctrine of Kashmir Saivism.... Now, modern science is finally grappling with

United Field Theory and eagerly waiting to examine the voluminous data emanating from the collision of sub-atomic particles in the LHC Project, Geneva; the interest of the philosophers who seek to formulate meta-narrative, is bound to deepen in the glorious legacy of the Spanda Shastras that constitute one of the pillars of the non-dualist Kashmir Saivism.”

Following this we have two soulful poems by Ambika Talwar from her book ‘My Greece: Mirrors and Metamorphoses’ While on one hand these poems evoke the nostalgia for the Greek past and its mythologies on the other it talks of the journey undertaken by the poet as a ‘sacred destiny’ which reveals multiple things about self to her.

In the end we have a photo feature on Ladakh by Deepak Kaw capturing the panoramic and magnificent views of the landscape and the monasteries.

Wisdom from Shiva's rattle drum (7)

Swami Paranand Tirth

हयवरट्

Ha Ya Va Rat

The order of universal manifestation .

Key words,

**Revelation and revelationability .Abrkadabra ,
Emprical soul. Testimony of evidence ,Doodle,
Prelest .**

Abstract:

The article talks about the Absolute and his deliberate conditioning and the reasoning of guileless seers of antiquity. Seventh beat of Shiva's rattledrum encrypts the mystery of creation . An abracadabra for syncing the microcosmic and universal patterns of awareness . In the beginning there was word The word as an attribute of Akash depicted as ह in this aphorism. Arcane formula with spellings disheveled need a preceptor to decipher them . र or the fire precedes व the seed syllable of water . ल or the earth comes from the next aphorism . Tantric practices regarding this aphorism are found in various canons . Mystic Nandikeshwara difference and deference from grammarian purists and other recipients of Nataraj Shiva's lessons . Mystic intuitive insight versus dialectic knowledge .

हयवरट्

“By the prowess of the intermediate manifestation of the absolute, conditioned in the innate description-less nescience these five elements viz. ether air, fire, water and earth are superimposed . Form this springs forth the universe with all its movable and immovable

,high and low varieties . I make obeisance to that absolute principle who is the abode of immeasurable bliss knowledge and immortality”
[Bhamati gloss on Shankara's commentary on Brahmsutra Bhasyam]

The condensation of consciousness as grosser manifestation from ether to the grossest earth is a process that can be learnt only from the revelations .

As a man walks briskly, says one of the upanisads following a guileless seer's simple modest logic the body gets hot similarly heat is generated from the air .As the man walks briskly and the body gets warm one perspires in the same way water is created from heat . When the man relaxes the perspiration solidifies and is deposited on the skin, the earth or the solid is thus formed from the water .

This sequence of successive modification into the penta-dimensional universal phenomena has been meticulously encrypted by the hoary saints of the yore, presumably to save themselves and their pupils from undue arrogance from the skeptics and determinists . Shiva in seventh beat of his rattle drum repeats this very secret . Huxley in his essay ‘The perineal philosophy’ writes that this perineal philosophy has been expressed in many languages . His intuitive insight into the process of revelationability and revelations aims at a singular and supramundane source of the revelations and the consistency of revelation ability . Needless to say that singular absolute principle who as it were would descend into the conditioned realm to “dirty his hand “is an essentially transcendental entity . By transcendence we are emphasising it's being beyond time space and substance and hence expression.

To describe some entity there must be six attributes viz genus, characteristics,activity,relation ,universality or speciality. Any entity bereft of these notions cannot be consistently described or expressed. So the mystique behind the source of revelation is that it is discreet and beyond expression,

expression being a posteriori of the essentially inexpressible nature of the source of revelations ,revelations can not lead to the direct subjective experience of the source of all revelations . But this doesn't reject the feasibility of revelation in helping an aspirant in ascertaining the essential nature of the universal self .They ,as one school of oriental thought calls them are the ultimate and only testimony of evidence .

Now let us assume Upanishads or the metaphysical canons of the Vedas are the only testimony of evidence of the power and process of creation . No other proof can vindicate a phenomena that predates even the dawning of such proof as the testimony of evidence . A determinist uses the same reasoning to refute the authenticity of revelation -ability . How can a posteriori part and parcel of the process of creation be a testimony of evidence regarding the process of the universal manifestation . In this sutra or rather all the Sutras which are consistent as the mystic encryptions of the revelations, the source is not an embodied entity like shiva he only unveils them ,but the solute principle which as yet another doctrine says is the निरपेक्षरवः or The spontaneously resonating word of god in the form of शब्दब्रह्म।

All these aphorisms are eternal and as one tantric canon abbreviates these to include the entire variety of the universal phenomena with two syllables अज्झलौ।This denotes all expressions which accrue from the combination and permutation of vowels and consonants .

One should meditate on अनचकमहलम् says VijnanBhairav ,all imagery doodle and prelest will subside and the aspirant will attain unison with the universal principle . A Vedic revelation says that god the creator pronounced भूः and the Bhuloka or the gross earth sprang forth owing to the state of unimpeded conceptualisation and actualisation अप्रतिहतसंकल्प the creation manifest by merely a conceptualisation of the creator . The Tantrik counterpart of the phenomena not only vindicates this but also

explains how it happens through this aphoristic beat of Shiva's rattle drum but also inducts the power and process of creation . Pratyabhijna philosophy maintains that the empericle soul is as much capable of carrying out the five functions carried out by Param Shiva despite the conditioning that reduces the absolute Shiva to the despoliation of an empericle soul . This explains why this mystic abracadabra has been widely used by tantriks and shamans for अनुग्रह which is mostly faith healing and imparting the spiritual knowledge . As we have said above this happens by syncing the proportions of the five elementary constituents of the phenomena in the microcosm and the macrocosm .

The aphorism हयवरट् Actually contains the five syllables in it .The last one ल comes in the next Sutras . The assumed insertion of ह has been justified by recent grammarians in their own way but the mystic explanation is that no single element can exist isolated just as there is no monosyllabic aphorism . The attribute, sound or word continues to pervade the grossest element earth denoted by the syllable ल। Nandikeshwara in his karika cites from the Taittiriya Upanisad as he explains ल the earth from which the purusa made from Anna and rasa (lit food and fluid) springs forth .

आधारभूतं भूतानामन्नादीनां च कारणम्।

अन्नाद्रेतस्ततो जीवः कारणत्वाल्लणीरितम्॥

The earth or the basic substratum is the base of all beings or other elements besides being the bed for growing food grains etc .which cause the sustenance of procreative agencies of seminal fluid which in turn accounts for the manifestation of jiva. Jiva or the empirical soul has been depicted as eternal in most of the Hindu metaphysical texts .Here the origin of jiva from the seminal fluid refers to the grosser manifestation of the jiva as foetus after insemination since jiva or soul is going to unite with it in the seventh week of conception . Thus

the eighth aphorism including the five syllables explains the power and process of the universal manifestation besides the esoteric order which when followed systematises the courses of spiritual pursuit of an aspirant who is required to reverse the process in order to get established in his essential nature.

The first four are in the correct order i.e. from ha or ether springs forth vayu i.e. ya . In the perfect still and subtlest vacuum there is a slight divergent movement . The analogy of quantum vacuum just fits into the context .In Galilean and Newtonian physics vacuum used to be defined as the absence or reduction of air in ether or space within a given dimension .This later evolved into the concept of quantum vacuum in the quantum mechanics of the thirties . The very minute charge that has been observed within a quantum vacuum also has some hints of how subtle and still motionless ether could have modified into the dynamic spanda which in turn is transmuted into energy or agni . These three are in fact the gradations of the same substratum in the order of grossness and conditioned pervasiveness . This being a highly arcane formula of the power and process of evolution of energy and matter from consciousness has been further encrypted by the lord . There is yet another maxim among ancient traditionalists who compiled most of their wisdom in poetry and verses – the sequence of meaning is more important than the order of recital .

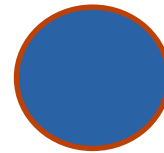
पाठक्रमार्थक्रमःबलीयान्भवति।

The order of generation of the five elementary constituents of the universal phenomena should be understood in the order of their origination and not the way they are given in the aphorism.

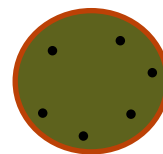
I read in some ancient Manuel of sorcery that all these fourteen aphorisms are also the abracadabra for exorcism .This formula in particular is used as faith healing abracadabra. Perhaps by repeating this the microcosmic proportion of the five elements syncs with the macrocosmic one. All ailments as per the tenets of aayurveda arise from the disturbed equilibrium of the five elements which are

further categorized as kapha –water, vat -air and pitta-fire . Earth has all these five and ether being all pervasive interlaces the rest of the four. So a repetition or meditation upon these five syllables can bring in some psycho kinetic change in the material realm . This is also prescribed by for the yogins to remove or get over diseases and ailments which occur as impediments in the path of yogic practice, say for example a yogin suffering from fever mustn't take a medicine but perform *samyam* of *ap tatwam* indicated by the syllable ‘‘Vam ‘‘ . *samyama* as per the tenets of Patanjali, is defined as a collective practice of withdrawal , retention and concentration .For example to pacify ailments arising from excessive drift and distraction caused by unruly flow of the air elements a yogi should do *samyama* on the earth element in order to gain stability whose seed syllable is lam [this is discreet or latent in this aphorism] This method is called ‘‘*ek tatwa dridhabhyasa*’’ in some metaphysical canons . which means a strong unswerving meditation on any one of the prescribed tatvas. Each tatwa has been attributed one syllable usually with a *nasalis* e.g. लंवरंयंहं etc. they also have a diagrammatic depiction and a color attributed to them .

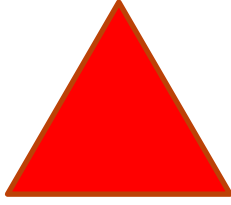
A vacant circle and blue colour signifies ether



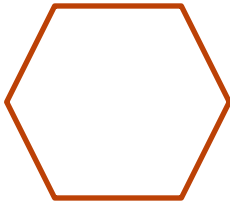
a circle with six dots stands for the air and bears a green or smokey hue



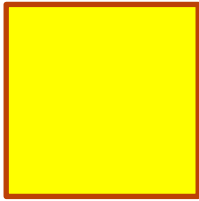
,a red triangle is a symbol of the element of fire



,a white hexagon for water



and a square with yellow colour depicts earth .



There is a similar semiotics in a practice of *karyasthalam in Buddhism* . in Theravada Buddhism the aspirant is required to focus on clay balls colored in various hues at various points of time . These are called कसिण् in Prakrit .since these are only clay balls i.e. the element of earth –these colored balls as it were pertain to the five characteristics [viz. smell ,taste , vision, touch and sound] of the element of earth . In many parts of India specially Bihar these balls of clay are worshipped even now but not with the required objective ,presumably only as a continuation of ancient and obsolete Buddhist practice.

These five syllables which have emanated from shivas rattle drum not only signify the five gradations of succession of creation simultaneously but are also consistent independently -one by one .This consistency is from a mystic stand point and not from a

conventional one . In the oriental semiotics the drum or [**chod** in Tibetan] denotes the element of ether with its characteristics as sound . In Sanskrit this *damaru* or *dhakka* is also called *kshudra dundubhi* or a petty drum . *Natananand nath*, a great mystic commentator on the treatise of his guru *Punyanand nanth* called 'Kamkala vilasa' [lit. sporting of the primordial will-] has proved that all sounds emanated from a percussion belong to the *pashyanti** realm [supra rational and transcending even the cosmic intelligence. in which the word and meaning have just begun to separate but are still in unison . Thus owing to their supra-mundane origin and with lord shiva as the author i.e. in as much as the playing of the rattle drum is concerned- these sutras have a great, deep and arcane import as compared to their merely grammatical implication which are relevant only in a parlance of descriptive linguistic of Panini and are meaning ful only in that particular context .

The Gita has aptly said that even a desire to know the yoga or the ultimate union rules out dialectic and discursive pursuit . Adishankara has also preached that after realising the ultimate scholarly knowledge is of no avail, and if the discursive knowledge is not culminating into the ultimate realisation it goes waste . This is not to refute the importance of shabdbrahma but to assert the supremacy of Intuitive insight over dry dialectic knowledge. Nandikeshwara was chosen to propagate the lineage of intuitive insight and mystic experience where as Panini and Vyadi etc. elaborated their system of grammar on these aphoristic onomatopoeia . The tradition of Sanak and Sanandandan etc is discreet and since we have no school of grammar attributed to them like Nandikeshwara they were also redeemed by lord Shiva through this arcane mystic wisdom which lead to the the realisation of the essential nature with or without the proceedings of discursive knowledge as per the competence of the aspirant .

*pashyanti -

*[1] Varna Ev to Shabdah iti upavarsa charya
(according to upavarsacharya varna or syllable
is a word) this monosyllabic theory of origin of
word predates the concept



Kashmir's Cultural Affinities with Himalayan Regions

Dr. S.S Toshkhani

Stretching from the Hindukush in the west to Myanmar in the east, the Himalayas are not a mere geo-physical phenomenon but the symbol of Indian civilizational ethos, the very soul and essence of India's spiritual and cultural traditions. The serene beauty of their eternal snows evokes a vision of the infinite and inspires a quest for the unknown. Their heights are the heights of the mind, their cosmic silence offering sublime moments of contemplation on the deeper and intrinsic meanings of life. It is in the caves and caverns of the Himalayas and on the serene shores of the rivers and lakes having their sources in the mountain range or on its lofty peaks high as the strivings and aspirations of man that sages and seers have meditated to discover the deep mysteries of life and death – eternal truths that illuminate the mind with the immensity of the cosmic vision of the oneness of man, nature and the divine in the infinity of time. In the lap of this vast and scintillating mountain range were born the “human and humane” value-systems that stress the sanctity of life and of nature and have moulded and shaped the Indian psyche since the earliest times. Perhaps that is why Kalidasa calls Himalayas the very embodiment of divinity, the measuring rod of the oceanic depths of India's consciousness.

Indeed, it is impossible to imagine India without this great mountain system which generates the creative rhythm and harmony that marks the life style of its people. That surely must be the reason why the great Shankaracharya chose to establish here the seats of the four Jagat Gurus in the places of pilgrimage as symbolic pillars of the directions supporting the spiritual unity of India. These bounding pillars are enclosed by the halo of what the ancient texts call Kashmir Mandala, completing the circle of a sacred geography towards which even today pilgrims from all directions walk. To experience the spiritual ecstasies awakened by the cultural ecologies of the enchanting vastness of the Himalayan landscape, there is perhaps no place better than Kashmir where forests and meadows, rivers and lakes appear to be symbols of the intimate relationship between immanent realities and transcendence.

Located between the Pir Panchal and Karakorum ranges, Kashmir has the distinction of being the largest valley of the Himalayas, and has contributed in many ways, along with other Himalayan regions with which it shares millennia of human activity, to the pan-Indian cultural significance of the great mountain. Is it not surprising, therefore, that the Himalayan character of the valley's culture has been consistently ignored and a forced amnesia created about it so as to de-contextualize it and deflect attention from actual facts of history. This is not to say that influences other than those that can be traced to the Himalayan civilizational and ecological ethos have not impacted the Kashmiri mind in any major way, but how far can encrustations and accretions be allowed to be seen as the real thing and the real thing hidden from sight?

The vast Himalayan amphitheatre has witnessed a great drama of movement and migration and mixing and commingling of peoples in the early dawns of pre-history, leading to long processes of acculturation through which diverse ethnic groups evolved into distinct communities with

their own peculiarities and characteristics and yet having many elements of commonality. Different cultural patterns and ways of living of the Himalayan communities emerged over the centuries from the peculiarly fascinating eco and geo-systems of the region, which at the same time displayed interesting strains of uniformity. Occupying a central place in this fascinating world of Himalayan culture, Kashmir has contributed immensely towards developing its unique traditions. The value systems, beliefs, rituals as well as art, architecture, folklore etc. shared by the people who inhabit it reflect a deep colouring of elements whose origins can be traced to Kashmir. As is well known, it came to be universally recognized as a centre of learning and culture, playing a crucial role, quite incommensurate with its geographical area, in creating the cultural climate in which Indian consciousness achieved its full efflorescence.

Historical factors and geographical location are largely responsible for promoting cross-regional exchanges and social interactions between Kashmir and other places situated along the Himalayas, which in turn led to its forging of highly significant linkages at different planes. For centuries this process went on, sometimes continuous and sometimes interrupted, sometimes intense and sometimes feeble, with far-reaching ramifications for art and culture, besides trade and commerce, in areas within the Indian watershed as well as across the Himalayas. Historical accounts are replete with references to political relations between Kashmir and ancient Gandhara, Kabul valley, Taxila and Swat in the north-west and also the erstwhile “hill states” of Punjab like Kangra, Chamba and Kullu, now known as Himachal Pradesh, not to speak of the hilly districts to the south of the Valley like Kashtwar, Bhadravah, Poonch and Rajouri in the Middle Himalayas which are now a part of the Jammu and Kashmir state.

The fact is that the territories immediately adjoining the Kashmir Valley and located across the Peer Panchal range have played very important, sometimes even crucial, role in its political and cultural history. These include Kashtwar, Bhadravah, Poonch, Rajouri, Ballawar etc., references to which are replete in the chronicles of the Jammu and Kashmir state. Of these Kashtwar has remained practically the very backyard of the Valley, providing, as it has done, refuge on several occasions to its kings fleeing from political upheavals caused by attacks of ferocious invaders from outside. But more importantly it provides the key to many unknown or forgotten facts of Kashmir’s cultural past. Kashtwari, the only recognized dialect of the Kashmiri language holds many a secret of its origin and development. Bhadravah, known as “Little Kashmir” for its close resemblance to the landscape and climate of Kashmir, is also linked to it for several folk-religious beliefs and practices though politically it has been tributary to Chamba. Poonch has also been very closely linked with the Vitasta Valley, though more on the plane of political history. The same can be said more or less about Rajouri. Sadly, however, no serious attempts have been made to study what constituted the cultural network that binds these areas in an intimate relationship.

Ancient chroniclers often refer to the intimate political and cultural links that existed between Kashmir and the erstwhile states of Kangra, Chamba and Kullu which have at one point of time in history or other been tributary to Kashmir, the latter at times wielding even direct political authority over them, with matrimonial relations often helping to reinforce the ties. While no direct historical records of Kashmir’s relations with what now comprises the Uttarakhand state are available, *bahis* maintained by the *Pandas* of Hardwar of their Kashmiri clients visiting them for obsequies of their dead kin, provide very interesting material for study including names of several important historical personages. Some of the *bahis* have images of the river Vitasta drawn on their dog-

eared and fragile pages, personified as a goddess and shown mounted on a fish in accordance with the Kashmiri tradition. The Nilamata Purana, which gives the story of the emergence of the Kashmir valley from the waters of the primordial Satisar lake, says that Kashyap Rishi who drained away the water of the lake, was at Kankhal near Hardwar on a pilgrimage at the time people approached him with the request to deliver them from the devastation caused by the demon Jalodbhava. This is an important pointer to the earliness and closeness of the contact between the people of the two regions connected by religious legends going back to hoary times.

As can be gleaned from the Nilamata, Rajatarangini and other ancient texts, affinities between Kashmir and other Himalayan regions begin with ethnography itself with the prehistoric racial groups like the Aryans, Nagas, Pishachas, Yakshas, Gandharvas, Dardas, Khashas, Kiratas or people of the Tibeto-Burman stock etc. who occupied ancient Kashmir being the very people who were spread along the entire Himalayan belt on the Indian side. While the historical identity of Nagas who along with Pishachas are said to have been the original inhabitants of Kashmir, remains to be settled, ancient Sanskrit texts like the Mahabharata and the Puranas are replete with references to them, and so are the Buddhist Jatakas. These references indicate that they were actual people, and not mere mythical beings as some scholars take them to be, who wielded tremendous influence not only in northwestern India but almost in every part of the country down to Andhra Pradesh in the south. But, it is not clear whether with all their influence they actually ruled over any region or not, or whether there they belonged to a racial group other than and antagonistic to the Aryans. Were they a people without any alphabetic culture despite their civilizational progress for no language or literature has been attributed to them, or were they actually an Aryan tribe itself at odds with often the dominant group but at times having cordial relations with it? As for the

Pishachas, Prakrit grammarians have referred to various varieties of the Paishachi Prakrit language and given some broad outlines of its peculiarities, but no work in Paishachi Prakrit has so far been traced, the much referred to Brihat Katha of Gunadhya having been lost for ever according to the legend. The area in which various Paishachi dialects are said to have been spoken practically covers the whole of India, which is highly improbable. The Pishachas are also associated with cannibalism and forcible marriage practices which include elopement. Scholars like Morgiensterne and Grierson consider them to have been speakers of the Pashai language of Kafiristan. The Pishachas have been shown in the Nilamata as a highly violent and uncivilized tribe with the Nagas severely dreading the prospect of living in co-habitation with them in prehistoric Kashmir as the sage Kashyapa had told them to. However, in Sanskrit texts like the Nilamata we see these ethnic groups mixing and commingling with each other with the passage of time to live in peace and harmony, the event finding its echoes in rituals and religious festivals.

The processes thus set into motion from the earliest times resulted in the formation of integrated societies with multi-layered cultural structures of which cultures of the individual integrating groups having their own distinctive characteristics formed different units. It may not be just possible for us today to identify any of these ethnic groups as definite entities, but the cultural footprints that they have left behind in the form of place names, festivals, rituals, modes of worship, music and dance, art forms, social mores, customs etc. can be traced to them without much difficulty. In the Kashmiri language the very word 'nag' denotes springs and waterholes as the aborigine Nagas were regarded as their presiding deities. In Himachal Pradesh too there are several springs with serpent deities besides numerous worship places associated with them. In Uttarakhand also temples and place names regarded as sacred to them are legion. Same is the case with place names associated with the Yakshas, who are

called *Jakhs* in the Uttarakhand region and worshipped as divinities.

The Yakshas, immortalized by Kalidasa in his *Meghadoot*, constitute another dominant ethnic community of prehistoric times who had to be propitiated by the people of ancient Kashmir to keep them at bay, the ritual of offering *gadabatta* or fish and rice to them on the *Khetsimavas* day being a relic of such propitiatory traditions. Ananda Coomaraswamy regards Yakshas to be water or tree spirits as they are invariably associated with waterholes or trees. From their description in the Mahabharata and other ancient texts the Kiratas do not seem to have belonged to an indigenous ethnic group but having possessed Mongolian features. These prehistoric cohabitants of the Himalaya eco-habitats faded into historical oblivion only after weaving strands of their beliefs and ways of life into the fascinating fabric that can be broadly described as Himalayan culture.

As an immense reservoir of concepts and ideas, knowledge and skills on which everyone was eager to draw upon it was natural for Kashmiris to have exerted a great influence on cultural as well as artistic plane on its neighbouring areas, more particularly those located along the Himalayan watershed. Thus it is that we find features of Kashmiri temple architecture and sculptural art marked by trifoliate arches, three-tiered roofs and triangular pediments crossed the geographic boundaries of the Valley and found their way into Himachal Pradesh and Ladakh. As is well known, *Lotsava* Rin-chen bzang-po (950 – 1005) took with himself 32 Kashmiri painters and craftsmen to Western Tibet to construct monasteries and paint murals on their walls at the behest of King Ye-shes-od of Guge. The amazing beauty of 10th-11th century Kashmiri style of pictorial art can be witnessed not only at Mangnang, Tholing and Tsaparang in the trans-Himalayan belt but also in places like Alchi in Ladakh and Tabo (Spiti) in Himachal Pradesh. Noted art historian

Pratapaditya Pal regards the murals of Alchi no less important than the frescoes of Ajanta in the history of Indian art. Kashmiri artistic traditions were also carried into the Himalayan regions in the shape of bronze images and scroll paintings. Perched on the Karakorum heights in the north-eastern Himalayas, Ladakh, now a part of the Jammu and Kashmir state, had always been in close contact with the Kashmir valley, politically but more prominently because of affinities provided by the Buddhist links. Kashmir's tremendous role in dissemination of Mahayana Buddhism to Tibet, Central Asia, China and other countries in the Trans-Himalayan region right from the time of Ashoka and Kanishka is well known and well documented. Ladakh too occupying the same geographical locus could not but be a part of this vast communication network based on political, religious, cultural and commercial considerations, particularly from early medieval times to at least the 16th century during the medieval period.

A subsequent development took place in the 18th -19th centuries when fear of religious persecution and lure of greener pastures drove Kashmiri painters to places like Kangra, Chamba, Basohli and Guler. It was the artistic genius of master painters from Kashmir like Seu Raina, Nainsukh, Chajju Bhagat and others which gave birth to the classic Pahari School of miniature painting famous for its subtlety, artistic excellence and appeal. Even at the folk level the scroll paintings quite similar to the Kashmiri *Gora Trai* can be seen in several places in Himachal Pradesh.

Sharada, one of the most important ancient scripts of India, which evolved in Kashmir probably earlier than the 8th-9th century and remained in use as a medium of written communication in an extensive area in the north-western parts of the country for a long period. It is also the mother of many other scripts like Takari and Gurumukhi and, according to several scholars, also of the Bodhi

alphabet used for writing Tibetan. According to *Chos-byun* of Bu-ston and also the Ladakh Annals, Tibetan scholar Thonmi Sambhot was sent by King Srong-bcan-sgam-po to Kashmir in the 7th century to learn grammar and devise a script for the Tibetan language and Thonmi returned with a 31 letter alphabet based on Nagari and Sharada characters. Whether the Tibetan alphabet is actually derived from it in Thonmi's time or later, the Sharada script has been yet another important unifying element in the Himalayan cultural and civilizational history.

Shiva and his consort Parvati, besides the Buddha, have been the most beloved deities of the Himalayan people. In fact the benign presence of Shiva, whose abode is said to be on Kailasa on the Himalayan heights, together with his various manifestations, is all-pervading in the region which is also the source of some of the holiest of Indian rivers, including the Ganga which is believed to flow from his matted locks. In Kashmir, where the Ganga does not flow we have a number of holy rivers from Doodhganga to Kishenganga carrying its name. Every inch of the mountain range from west to east, from Kailas to Amarnath is sacred to Shiva, abounding in places of pilgrimage reflecting his glory, with numerous peaks and crags, caves and caverns, rocks and cliffs resounding with legends associated with him, the God of gods. The same is case with Parvati, who is the great mountain's own daughter. The Nilamata Purana, a sixth century Sanskrit text which gives Kashmir's own creation myth, describes the whole Kashmir Valley as her very embodiment. Lake after lake, pond after pond, stream after stream, forest grove after forest grove, rock after rock, and peak after peak tells the poignant story of her love for the land. Parvati is said to have incarnated herself as the river Vitasta, the beloved river of the Kashmiris whose birthday they celebrated till not too distant a past by floating earthen lamps on its gentle waves. On the grassy slopes of the beautiful meadow Yusmarg she is said to have roamed as *yoshita* or a young girl, lending her name to the place (wrongly supposed to have

been named after Yusuf Shah Chak who ruled over Kashmir before Akbar made it a part of his Mughal empire). At the level of folk religion, many hilly goddesses, like Sharika and Ragnya in Kashmir and Nanda Devi and numerous other local goddesses in other parts of the region, have been identified with her. At a higher mystic and esoteric plane, this has led to proliferation of cults associated with Shaiva and Shakta and also Buddhist Tantrism (of the Mahayana, Mantrayana and Vajrayana variety). Tantra then has been the abiding belief system deeply entrenched in the entire region from Kashmir down to Kamaroop -- the devotional and ritualistic constant of the faith that receives its values from Kashmir Shaiva metaphysics or doctrines of Mahayana. The immense popularity of the Bhairava or Mother Goddess cults at the level of folk religious beliefs and practices shows how strong these traditions have been and still are.

In fact, folk-religious influences, like folklore, have manifested itself in numerous forms to become an important part in the religious life of the communities of the entire region, interacting with other cultural currents from literature to rituals. Winning the favour of folk deities for power and prosperity, fertility and health through rituals form the core of religion for ordinary masses everywhere, leading to their intervention and involvement in day to day life of their worshippers. Associated with seasons and agricultural cycles, festivals and folk religious practices of the region have features closely related to the identity of the social milieus in which they are performed, often full of music and dance to intensify elements of ecstasy and devotion. As in Kashmir and Himachal Pradesh, so in Uttarakand and other regions of the Indian Himalayas, folk religion forms a lively aspect of the structure of religious consciousness of the people. While the folk deities are approached for prosperity and happiness, they are expected to respond with compassion as well as magical power to fulfill the devotees' worldly desires. We have referred to the cults of the Bhairava and the mother

goddess above as a common element in various folk religious modes of worship, there is also a whole pantheon of demonology present in each of these modes which is sought to be appeased through various mystical and magical practices.

Language is yet another field that opens up a whole horizon of affinities between the languages of the Himalayan regions evolved from and pulsating with the beauty and vitality of Sanskrit, the embodiment of Indian thought and culture. Linguists have drawn attention to the importance of studying Kashmiri for understanding the evolution of modern Indian languages from their Old Indo-Aryan origins over the centuries as well as their present relations. The dynamics of creating vocabularies that the Himalayan languages share as a legacy from Sanskrit is revealed not only by the word-stock that they draw upon but also by the structural matrix explaining their formative processes. The secret of affinities between these languages in their present form lie in their connection with the Sanskrit traditions that have given them their shape from their etymologies to their morphologies. The *chh*-based auxiliary verb forms of Kashmiri, for instance, derived from the Sanskrit root *kshi*, are quite similar to the corresponding auxiliary verb forms in Kumanoni and other Uttarakhand dialects. The similarities, of which a whole world opens up in lexicographical items as well as their “semantic spectra”, to borrow a phrase from Dr. Lokesh Chandra, could make a very interesting study, even though Sanskrit is in near total eclipse in today’s Kashmir

Architecture and artistic skills are also features having a wide impact on the life styles of large segments of population in these areas could well form the subject of a very rewarding study.. Close resemblance between the traditional residential architecture of Kashmir with its carved wooden bay windows and eaves, columns and beams, doors and latticed window panes and the traditional houses in different

parts of Himachal Pradesh is something that cannot be missed by the discerning eye. Equally interesting are the elements that link the life-patterns of nomadic communities like the Gujjars and Bakarwals of Jammu and Kashmir and the Gaddis of Himachal Pradesh besides several other small tribal and pastoral societies who have their own sub-cultures which they have managed to sustain even in most adverse political conditions.

The unique thing about the Himalayan regions, it will be interesting to note, is the role played by eco-systems in shaping human ideas and fostering cultural expressions. The rivers flowing through the entire belt have divided the mountain ranges into their catchment areas, providing the most essential life sustaining element water for human habitations to flourish. Scientists are rightfully describing these Himalayan ranges as “water towers of modern civilizations”. Along with water and snow forests form an important feature of Himalayan identity, supporting a vast diversity in the biosphere. It is because of the forests that we have life patterns associated with cattle rearing, food -gathering, cottage industries, trade, medicinal herbs, farming; it is because of them that we have songs and music and dance and even spiritual contemplation and philosophy in these regions. The diversity is there, but the unity is also palpable, for there is something in the nature and behaviour of the Himalayan people that comes straight from the ecology of their habitat.

The “deeper, inner core” of Kashmiri ethos belongs to paradigms that have evolved in the Himalayas, on the banks of the rivers flowing through its valleys and ravines since the dawn of civilization. The perennial flow of their waters “gave rise to the centrality of flow, movement and progress in thought”, to quote Dr. Lokesh Chandra again. “Banks of rivers with water flowing became the inspiration for the spontaneity of regulation from within, the basis of value systems of *samskara*.” For those,

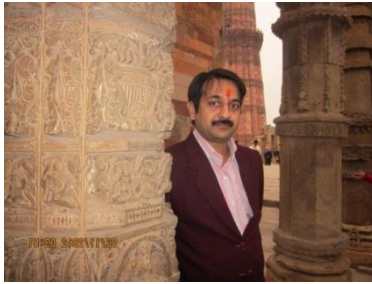
therefore who want to access this core, it will be a futile exercise to look for it in the paradigms that have evolved in the stasis of vast expanses of desert sand and imposed on its Himalayan soul. Kashmir's indigenous cultural expressions have been inspired by pine and deodar scented breezes and the music of murmuring rivers winding their way through its length and breadth. Their true meaning can be grasped only when viewed in a perspective provided by the ecologies of which it forms a natural part.

It will be rewarding for researchers, therefore, to give up burrowing holes through heaps of historical falsehoods in the belief that they are excavating facts about Kashmir and its culture and look for the thread that binds Kashmiris together in unity with the people of the other regions of the Himalayas. Such an inquiry shall have its own thrills and excitements for it shall open up for them breathtakingly interesting vistas of social customs, religious traditions, ritualistic behaviour, costumes, life styles, folklore, art and various other forms of creative expression besides the linguistic situation and other spheres of everyday life. Those who bring up Central Asia and its Sufis every time Kashmir's culture is mentioned should know that the Silk Route was more a route of the Sutras introduced, translated and interpreted mostly by scholars and monks from Kashmir, that Kashmiris were everywhere in Central Asia in the first millennia of the Christian era, that Kumarajiva, son of a Kashmiri trader and Kuchean princess was the greatest scholar the region has ever produced taking as he did the Lotus Sutra to the farthest end of the Far East - being called one of the "four suns" of Buddhism for that - and that Kashghar was known as Kashi for being a centre of Sanskrit learning which Khotan too had become till it fell to the Karkhanavids in 1006. It were the Mahayana and Vajrayana monks from Kashmir who tamed the fierce tribes of the area by transmitting the holistic message of the Buddha and taught them the Sutras. And not just Buddhism, Kashmiri scholars introduced the Sanskrit language and Sanskrit wisdom throughout the trans-Himalayan belt and Kashmiri artists painted frescoes there in places like Dun Huang,

bringing the art of Ajanta to the region. Travellers traveling along the Silk Route would carry bronze images of Avalokiteshwara with them beautifully carved in Kashmir as the deity of protection.

The case for viewing Kashmir in the perspective of Himalayan culture is indeed very strong. Unfortunately, this remains a totally neglected research area even though venturing into it can lead us to amazing facts about Kashmir's indigenous belief systems, religious expressions, life-patterns and ritualistic behaviour, philosophy, traditional arts and artistic skills, language and literary traditions, folklore, folk-religious beliefs and practices including demonology and animistic and pantheistic worship, oral and intangible heritage, eco-cultural systems and social structure..

(Dr. S.S Toshkhani is a poet, linguist, writer and a thinker. He has contributed substantially to Kashmiri heritage and carried out modern research in various fields of Kashmiri literature, history, religion, art and social sciences.)



Spanda: signature of Existence

Niraj Kumar

Idea of 'spanda' is at the heart of the remarkable doctrine of Kashmir Saivism. Etymologically speaking, Spanda is a 'throb', a vibration, an oscillation between manifestation and disappearance, emergence & dissolution. Now, modern science is finally grappling with United Field Theory and eagerly waiting to examine the voluminous data emanating from the collision of sub-atomic particles in the LHC Project, Geneva; the interest of the philosophers who seek to formulate meta-narrative, is bound to deepen in the glorious legacy of the Spanda Shastras that constitute one of the pillars of the non-dualist Kashmir Saivism.

There are two schools of thought in modern physics that are at loggerhead. While adherents of Standard Model pit for the 'field theory' of physical universe; in recent years the bandwagon of chaos/fractal theorists have gained prominence who posits the idea of 'scalar invariance of structures' in a dynamic universe. The field theory presuppose 'vibratory mode' as the fundamental nature of universe. Fields are produced by oscillatory movement and the quantum theory presupposes linear oscillators at work at sub-atomic level. Particles invariably have quantum numbers like spin number. The String theory postulates existence of one-dimensional strings that consists of oscillating loops vibrating as various sub-atomic particles like electrons and protons. String theory that considers varying oscillation of string as the cause of manifestation of different particles lies at the extreme end of this dominant

paradigm. The whole universe gets reduced to mere vibration, mere throb of "physical nothingness", since physicality itself is mere an appearance of vibration.

Neuroscientists have discovered in last decade phenomena of synchronous oscillation of neurons in the cerebral cortex and have proposed that this pattern of synchronous pulsation in the brain generates a mechanism whereby various sensory data contribute to the perception of 'wholeness' of observed phenomena. There cannot be a perception of unified object without this mechanism. Heart beat, breathing, and similar kind of internal rhythm are present across biological world. Pulsation in biological system is explicitly visible if one observes a beheaded chicken. Muscles continue to rhythmically expand and contract even though the body is cut into pieces. Rhythm precedes the birth and continues even after death. Scientists at the Blue Brain Project at Geneva which is building artificial mammalian brains including that of human beings were surprised to observe bizarre phenomena last year. Artificial silicon neurons respond to external stimuli and pulse and flash synchronously. Pulsation seems to be present beyond biological world. All living beings survive by the process of glycolysis i.e. glucose is broken down and energy is produced. Now, the glycolytic cycle itself has been found to be pulsating. Discovery of temporal oscillation at the level of chemical processes at sub-cellular level shows the ubiquity of spandan. Case of Belousov-Zhabotinsky reaction in chemistry where the concentration of chemicals pulsates with different colors is often cited by theorist of dynamic system.

Physicists are finding themselves perturbed by observing certain interesting phenomena. There is a set of particle called 'neutrino'. Neutrinos have 0 charge and insignificant mass. Neutrinos form a shadow universe since these don't interact much with the matter that constitutes us. therefore, millions of neutrinos from the sun,

cosmic rays are continuously passing through us without causing any interaction. Proton-proton collision creates new particles that immediately decay into neutrinos. LHC at Geneva is experimenting with the behavior of neutrinos. There are three families of neutrinos (muon, electron, tau). Scientists are perplexed to find that one type can oscillate into another. Therefore, oscillation/pulsation seems to be inherent characteristic at much deeper level than even beyond the appearance of our type of 'universe'.

On the other hand, the fractal theorists discover reiteration of self-similar structure/form at various scale of the universe. Like Russian Matryoshka dolls where self-similar dolls are nested one inside the other. The hierarchy and nesting of self-similar structure is easily discernible in cauliflower or broccoli where tiny pieces look much like the whole vegetable. The fractal paradigm can be summed up in philosophical term as 'microcosm reiterate macrocosm'. The only difference is in the scale of seeing. Fractals are found in every dynamic system. In reality, everything in the universe is in flux. There is no absolute rest or changelessness in the phenomenal universe.

The future of science depends upon the experimental result at the LHC. If the elusive Higgs boson is discovered, the SUSY(Super Symmetry) theory, String theory and dozens of hypothesis based on the presupposition of 'wave/field/oscillation' at the root of physical universe will get fresh lease of life. But, if the nature of Higgs particles itself appear "fractal", the whole science, consequent technology and future of human civilization will take an unprecedented turn.

The Spanda shastras unify the two conflicting paradigm of contemporary times, The Spanda doctrine espouses "vibration" as well as hierarchy, nesting & recurrence of self-similar

structure of the Being. Spanda shastras contain the seed of future of our human civilization.

Situating emergence of Spanda School in matrix of history

The origin of Spanda doctrine can be attributed to Vasugupta (c. 800A.D.). In the Spandanirnaya, the commentary on the Spandakarika; Ksemaraja (10th century), the cousin and pupil of Abhinavagupta, mentions how the SivaSutras were revealed (unmilitamahima) to Vasugupta by Lord Siva Himself. Vasugupta received guidance in dream. He went to the sacred Mahadeva Mountain and found the Siva Sutras engraved on the surface of the rock. The Siva Sutras contain 78 sutras. There is a difference of opinion on the authorship of Spandakarika, the 51 –sutra commentary on the Siva Sutras. Ksemaraja, Maheshvarananda and Daniel Odier attribute the composition of the karika to Vasugupta. Bhaskara & Utpala mentions Kallata, the disciple of Vasugupta as the writer of Spandakarika. Jaideva Singh opines that Vasugupta composed the karikas and taught to Bhatta Kallata who only publicized them.

The revelation of Siva Sutras to Vasugupta seems to be determined by the criss-crossing religious and philosophical trajectories prevalent in Kashmir during his time. Sankaracarya (788-820 A.D.) had visited Kashmir and reinvigorated Vedanta philosophy by incorporating the then dominant conception of Reality as a form of Non-dual Absolute as propounded by Nagarjuna in the Madhyamika school of Buddhism. Around 760 A.D., King Trisong Detsen of Tibet invited Padamshambhava and Santarakshita (705-762A.D.) to Tibet. Santarakshita was the then abbot of famous Nalanda University. Both of them introduced Buddhism into Tibet and indulged in translation of Dharmic texts. Later, they founded the first Buddhist monastery in

Tibet at Samye near Lhasa in 767A.D. King declared Buddhism as state religion in 762 A.D. They must have passed through Kashmir during their sojourn in Tibet and influenced the local Kashmiri scholars. In fact, many of the translators in the team were Kashmiri Pandits. Ananta was the interpreter for Santarakshita in Tibet. Kashmiri scholars like Dharmakaradatta, Jinamitra, Danasila, Sraddakaravarman, Ratnavajra, Lakshmi, Subhutisristani, Somanatha, Mahajana, Suksmajnana, Parahitabhadra, Parahita, Kumarsri, Trilakalasa, Kanakavarman were some of the well known scholars and translators from Kashmir who were invited to perform preaching or translation work in Tibet. Tibetan king organized a two-year dharma debate at Samye (792-794 A.D.), known in history as the 'Council of Lhasa'. A master of Ch'an Buddhism, Hwa-shang Mo-ho-Yen was propagating the view of sudden enlightenment that springs without much effort. Ch'an Buddhism had become popular in China after being introduced by Bodhidharma who hailed from Kanchipuram during early 6th century. Ch'an Buddhism on its way to Japan evolved as 'Zen' which outrightly rejects logic as a way to reach Truth. Kamalshila, the disciple of Santarakshita and a resident of Magadha defeated Ch'an master in the debate on the nature of 'emptiness'. Since then, trajectory of Buddhism in Tibet followed Indian path and the Chinese influence on religious evolution of Tibetan Buddhism was arrested. Victory of Kamalshila must be known to Kashmiri scholars who often accompanied Buddhist masters from India into Tibet.

Subsequent to Kamalshila's victory, Indian Buddhism emanating from the centre of Nalanda was officially declared as the state religion in Tibet. This is known as the 'First spreading'. But, soon it met a serious assault at the hands of an unpopular King. Langderma ascended the throne in Tibet in 836 A.D. and began a drive to cleanse Tibet from Buddhist influence. Monasteries were destroyed and monks were reconverted to lay person or else sent into exile. Though Langderma was soon

assassinated in 842 AD, Tibet fell into domestic upheaval and civil war. This situation continued for more than a century.

The exile of Buddhist monks from Tibet and revelation of Siva Sutra to Vasugupta are synchronous occurrence. There is strong possibility that Buddhist monks fled to Kashmir also, which was famous as the abode of wisdom. This might have initiated a process of philosophical synthesis in Kashmir. The way Siva Sutra is stated to be revealed to Vasugupta is reminiscent of the legend of revelation of Prajnaparamita Sutras to the great Madhyamika philosopher, Nagarjuna in the land of nagas. In Nyingma tradition (the oldest school of Buddhism in Tibet founded by Padamsambhava during 8th century). The concept of terton' and 'terma' was widely prevalent. Terma is the revealed teachings which past masters hid for discovery by later tertons(discoverers) at appropriate time. Generally, the secret knowledge(terma) was physically discovered as engravings in rocks or caves or many a times in intuitive flash in mind itself.

There is preponderance of possibility of deep influence exerted by the exiled Buddhist masters upon discovery of Siva Sutras by Vasugupta. Kashmir was under the rule of Karkotas(626-855 AD). They followed the Vaishnav sect. Spread of religious ideas is inextricably linked with the proximity of a particular religious worldview with the political authority. Since major monasteries and institutions were funded by the imperial authorities, the sects vied with each other to mould the viewpoint of the Kings & their ministers or else to modify their own teachings to accommodate the viewpoint of the King. More than two century of rule by Vaishnava Karkotas couldn't have provided fertile ground for Saivism to spring and flourish.

Though, Saivism was on ascendance all across India and South-East Asia at this juncture. In Tungbhadra-Kaveri and Tungbhadra- Bhima zone of Karnatka, construction of new Siva temples far outnumbered temples/monasteries of other religious sects. Similar pattern is evident in Andhra. Pala dynasty encouraged and supported spread of Buddhism from Tibet to South-East Asia. Palas contributed significantly in building and maintaining major Buddhist centres like Nalanda, Vikramshila, Semapura, Trikatuka, Uddandapura, Jagaddala. Devpala's (period of rule from 812-850 AD.) son Mahendrapala was strongly attracted towards Saivism. Mahendrapala (850-865 AD.) built two temples, one for Buddha and the other for Siva. This suggests a build-up of fusion of Saivite philosophy & practices with Buddhism since major centres for innovation of concepts in Buddhism were dependent on Pala's support.

During same period, Saivism was gaining pre-eminence in Khmer kingdom and the fusion process of Saivite-Buddhist texts & practices gained impetus. During the 9th & 10th century, the Saivite idea of 'Lokeshwar' was fully internalized by the tantric Mahayana Buddhists. Kings were portrayed as avatars of Siva as in Angkor and even as Bodhisattava as in the temple at Bayon. The cult of heruka emerged in Buddhism based upon iconography inspired by the imagery of Siva. Since, single donors supported both religions, both stream were deploying greater degree of appropriation to win the adherence of the political authorities.

Buddhanirvana of Cham Kingdom in Indo-China records that his father, Somnatha donated two viharas for Buddha and two temples to Siva. Similar assimilation and appropriation is evident in eastern Java. George Coedes mentions in his work, *The Indianized States of Southeast Asia* (1968) that a syncretic cult of Siva-Buddha evolved both in Mataram (Central Java) and Angkor. Two great works appeared simultaneously under the patronage of the Mataram ruler Sindok (929-948 A.D.), the

Javanese Ramayana and the Tantric Buddhist treatise Sang Hyang Kamahayanikan. Airlangga (1010-1050 AD), the founder of the Kahuripan kingdom was consecrated as the King in 1019-20 AD by a Buddhist as well as a Saiva priest in Mataram. During Singhasari and Majapahit period (1222-1292 & 1293-1500 AD), this syncretism continued to flourish. Imperial formations provided simultaneous support to both Saivism as well as Buddhism.

Even in Kashmir, Lalitaditya (724-761 AD) gave equal patronage to every sect, Hindu or Buddhist. He constructed temples for Siva as well as statues of Buddha. But, his successor Karkota kings were weak & unimaginative. Avantivarman (855-883 AD) who ascended the throne at the time when Tibet was in the throes of civil war causing massive exodus of scholars to adjoining areas, founded the Utpala dynasty. He patronized Kallata, the pupil of Vasugupta who is credited with writing the commentary on Siva Sutra, the Spandakarika. His reign is credited with effervescence in every aspect of life in Kashmir. It is an open question whether the impetus came from scholar-émigrés from Tibet or was it wholly nativistic?

Some contours for this fusion in a vast geo-cultural region can be drawn. The Siddha tradition gained prominence during 9th century with the advent of Saraha. Saraha, too, was associated with Nalanda tradition. The Siddha repudiated the use of language of metaphysics engaged by scholars and sang caryapadas) in apabhramsha, the mother of modern -day languages like Hindi, Bengali or Oriya. They were the carrier of the fusion process. They were the great alchemist of ideas and took the best practices from the flourishing sects. They emphasized more on direct realization rather than contemplation over obtuse philosophy. Since, they wanted to take their teachings directly to people and not to the imperial overlords; they introduced theistic elements in their teachings which can attract all and sundry. Siddhas accepted Siva, Jina, and Buddha to be

one and same from different views. Tibetan teachings of Padamsambhava carried the stories about experiences of Siddhas to Tibet. It is in this fusion which has left indelible mark on history of various sects in India, Nepal, Bhutan, & Tibet. Kapalika, a fiery Saivite sect that flourished in Kashmir during this period mentions Nagarjuna as one of 12 pupils of the sect. In Guhyasiddhi Sangraha, it was stated that Vajrayana was inseparable from Saiva and Pashupat system as basic practice for both is Mahamudra. Some consider Kapalika tradition itself as a fragment of Niruttara tantra practices of Nyingma tradition. There is strong overlap between Natha, Siddhas and Kapalikas. Name of Gorakhnath, Jalandhar Nath, Nagarjuna as lineage guru are common in all these sects.

Kumarila, a Buddhist monk, who later converted into Saivism is a good example of fluid matrix. There is strong likelihood that Saivism in new avatar sprouted in Kashmir upon the vehicle of Tibetan Buddhism following tumultuous affairs after Langderma ascension.

In Spandanirnaya, the commentary on the Spandakarikas, Ksemraja emphasizes that the Spandakarika is basically presentation of Mahamudra, the cosmic gesture, which later became the foundation of Kagyu lineage in Tibetan Buddhism. The great transmission master of the Kagyu sect, Naropa (1016-1100 AD.) though born in a royal family of Bengal, went for study to Kashmir at the age of mere 11, since at that time Kashmir had emerged as an important seat of Buddhist wisdom. In 1049 A.D., Naropa went to Nalanda and was elected as an abbot. Naropa's name is mentioned in the list of 84 Siddhas along with familiar names like Gorakh, Saraha and Matsyendranath. Naropa epitomizes the close connection and fluid exchanges between Nalanda, Kashmir, Tibet & Bengal. Naropa received Mahamudra from his guru, Tilopa who had four transmission that included mahamudra, tantra, bardo and candali (correspondence with Kundalini, the

Mother shakti encased within body) from different teachers. Now, mahamudra is the ultimate goal not only in Kagyu sect and Kashmir Saivism (it is epitomized in tandava dance of Siva), but also found as an important aspect of teaching among Natha & Siddha sects.

Bodhibhadra, the disciple and successor of Naropa at Nalanda was a Kashmiri pandit. Sri Bhadra Bodhibhadra is credited with translating the texts of Kalachakra tradition. He was also the teacher of Atisa Dipankar (b.982-1054 A.D.) who went to Tibet in 1040 A.D. upon invitation of Tibetan king and is credited with reforming the excesses that had crept into Buddhist practices due to misinterpretation of texts. Abhinavagupta who synthesized various schools of Kashmir Saivism in his magnum opus, Tantraloka, pays obeisance in the beginning of the text to Matseyndranath. Kalachakra tradition considers Tantraloka as an authoritative text in their practices. There is so much fluidity among various sects, emerging syncretism and inter-textuality that sometimes sense of distinction (apoha) itself evaporates.

Take the case of Matsyendranath. Tantraloka begins with salutation to him. He is considered direct disciple of Siva. His name is encrypted in Buddhist legends. He is identified with Avalokiteshwar in Buddhism. In Nepal, he is the patron saint. This concept of Ishwar/Adinath/Swayambhu is common in every sect during this period. Probably, this kind of fusion took place in the centre of Nalanda and spread to the Himalayan region comprising Kashmir, Tibet, Nepal, Bhutan, Assam. The Himalayas seem to be a crossroad between Kashmir and Buddhist as well as non-Buddhist tradition of Eastern India. What can be stated as the better synthesis & synchronous throb in the geo-cultural zone than the fact that the sacred mountain of Kailash and the pristine lake of Mansarovar is revered by both Hindus and Buddhists.

Saivism cannot be viewed in isolation from the criss-crossing & fluid trajectories of dynamic religious ideas emanating from various centres across South and Southeast Asia. The evolution of these trajectories were often determined by the imperial formations as well as advent of creative genius like Gorakh, Saraha, Padamsambhava, Naropa, Matsyendranath, Vasugupta, Abhinavagupta. In all likelihood, expulsion of Buddhist scholars during first half of the ninth century to adjoining areas caused effervescence in Kashmir analogous to the process of renaissance created in Italy after the fall of Constantinople and exodus of the Arab scholars into Italy. Since most of the interpreter as well as translators in Tibet were Kashmiris, they would have returned to their native place and reinvigorated the debate, fusion, assimilation with fresh ideas of synthesis, theistic God in spite of a philosophy of 'vacuity' and Absolute monism carried in their mind through translation of great works of Buddhist tradition.

Sixteenth Karmapa often stated that Kashmir Saivism is the 'southern lineage' while Karma-Kagyü's cakrasamvara tantra is the 'northern tradition'. But, emergence of Kashmir Saivism was determined by further local dynamics of evolution of vedantic thought and phoneme-transcendentalism. A brief description of main tenets of Spanda school of Kashmir Saivism is necessary before harping upon charting out influence of other thought- trajectories.

Basic tenets of Spanda School

There are four schools in Kashmir Saivism namely, Krama, Kula, Spanda and Pratyabhijña. Every school has certain common conceptual framework like primacy of consciousness over material world, physicality of appearance, Reality as manifestation of Absolute consciousness, non-duality, and a close interconnection between phoneme and

phenomena. The basic postulate of Spanda school is the dynamic nature of the fundamental Reality, that the universe is the grosser manifestation of vibration mediated through sound/letters/phonemes. The vibration emanates from the 'ecstasic self-recurrent consciousness'. (Jaideva Singh, Spanda-Karikas: The Divine Creative Pulsation, p.xvii). Everything in this Universe throbs, but the genesis of throb is atemporal vibration of Supreme Consciousness. If a practitioner can learn to contemplate over the movement of tiniest of entity or phenomena, the aspirant can reach the source, the Absolute consciousness. This brings the state of liberation, permanent bliss and the will of the realized person merges with the will of the Supreme Siva. He becomes one with Siva.

Since, Sivasutra revealed to Vasugupta is an agam sastra, the first commentary, Spanda-Karikas being composed by his disciple Kallata, main propositions of these two texts form the foundation of the Spanda School of Kashmir Saivism.

Siva Sutras contain 77 verse in three parts which reflects the Trika philosophy, the unique feature of Kashmir Saivism. First part contains 22 aphorisms, second ten, while the final forty-five. The very first aphorism, 'caitanyamatma' (the creative state of the Highest consciousness is the Reality of everything) posits primacy of consciousness over matter. Thence follows aphorism on recurrence of triad structure at various level of manifestation. Three kind of bondage, three kind of knowledge, three state of consciousness (waking, dreaming, sleep) (verse 1.7-1.10). An authentic yogi enjoys the oneness of awareness in all the abovementioned state of consciousness. And he gains Siva's unlimited power of creativity. The second part begins with the aphorism, 'cittam mantrah (mind is mantra) (verse 2.1). Guru is the means to knowledge of the wheel of Matricakra (wheel of alphabets). The world is seen as manifestation of words. The universe is gross manifestation of

SabdaBrahma(Highest sound-consciousness). At the highest level of Paravak (beyond speech) words (sabda) and the meaning(artha) are in a state of unity. It is only in the descent of manifestation that differentiation occurs. The world as well as word are manifestation of matraka(phonemes). Matraka emerges from primordial 'supreme speech', Paravak, the original spoken Word of Siva. Para-Vak is the creative power (vimarsh) of ParamSiva. Mind of practitioner becomes 'mantra' itself by intense contemplation of the deity inherent in the mantra. Mantras are not mere mumbo-jumbo, but a gradual ascent towards para-vak and the Ultimate Reality.

Matricakra is the art to unite the subjective world and the objective world through phoneme-universe. There are two series of alphabets in Sanskrit-16 vowels representing Siva-principle(subjective world) and 36 consonants for the Sakti- principle(manifested, objective world). There are 50 alphabets and the Universe is manifestation of the alphabetic soup. Siva has five Shaktis-cit sakti(anuttara/Highest consciousness), ananda Sakti(bliss), Iccha Sakti(will), jnana Sakti(knowledge) and Kriya Sakti(action). Siva ceaselessly acts in the world through these five Saktis in manifestation(sristi), maintenance(sthiti), withdrawal(samhara), concealment(trirodhana) and grace(anugraha)(Verse 3.30).

Based upon work of earlier grammarians, the aphorisms presuppose three stages of manifested sound-pasyanti, madhyama,& vaikhari. Wheresoever there is motion, there is vibration and sound. Spandana is the throb of ParamSiva, a movement without succession. Thence arises the soundless sound, nada and bindu (light), the two aspects of creative Siva, prakash (manifestation) and vimarsha(concretization) symbolized respectively by bindu and nada. Para-Vak, the supreme speech gradually materializes into physical universe as syllables and

alphabets through three stages pasyanti, madhyama, vaikhari. Para-Vak is the vimarsha aspect of Param-Siva, the power of 'aham'(self-awareness). Pasyanti is the visual sound, the image of idea before expression. Madhyama stands in the middle between ideal form of speech and spoken word, between visual speech and vocal speech. Vaikhari is the uttered sound. Matrikas are phonetic constituents of vaikhari, while vaikhari represents kriya sakti. Matrika are the seed of every language from which all kinds of words and sentences emerge. Since, there are three-fold energies of Siva i.e. Para (subjective), Parapara(cognitive) and Apra(objective), man can realize his identity with Siva through cognitive path. That makes the world of 'matrika' and mantras very important for the practice of an aspirant. Since mantras arise from the spanda principle, they contain the aspect of Siva.

First verse of Second Awakening of Siva Sutra is 'cittam mantrah' (mind is mantra). It is through the deep awareness of one's identity with the Supreme consciousness embodied in a mantra and thus becoming identical with that Supreme consciousness, mind itself becomes mantra. Ksemaraja explains in the commentary, Vimarsini that it is the mind (cittam) itself which is mantra and not mere a combination of letters.

The first vowel 'A'(a) stands for the ultimate reality since there is nothing beyond this. It is the anuttara. When 'A' self-reflects, it duplicates and reunites with itself, creating A-A (Aa). Aa represents 'ananda' principle. Phoneme 'I' signify iccha Sakti, the desire for manifestation. 'U' connotes unmesha(manifestation of iccha in ideal state of jnana). A is the root of all creation and through 'I'(iccha) comes into manifestation (u), unmesa. Anuttrara manifests in infinite form through combination with iccha and this describes the svachhanda (freedom) aspect of Param-Siva.

In matricakra, Panini's rule of grammar is followed to create a linguistic universe that corresponds with the physical reality. Panini's grammar had significant influence over scholars in Kashmir. Candragomin founded the Candra school of Sanskrit grammar in Kashmir. Lalitaditya's grandson, Jayapida ruled Kashmir for 31 years (782-813 A.D.). He himself was a student of Sanskrit grammar and one of his ministers, Vamana was the author of Kashikavritti, a commentary on Panini's work. It is the influence of Panini & Bhtrihari that shaped the esoteric ideas of matricakra. Structural resonance recurs all around. Panini divided his magnum opus, Ashtadhyayi into eight chapters. Patanjali, who wrote Mahabhasya, a commentary on Panini is known for his concept of Ashtanga yoga. In matricakra, similar structure is reiterated. There are two garlands of letters containing vowels and consonants. There are 16 vowels with 8 pairs like 'A', 'Aa'. There are 8 vargas of consonants each governed by great Mother Sakti. It is not mere a coincidence that Kalhana chronicled Rajtarangini in similar structure with 8 chapters and used 'tarang'(etymologically homologous to spanda) in his historical narrative about this period in Kashmir.

By employing the technique of pratyahara i.e. combining the beginning and the end, udaya and pralaya, the whole universe can be perceived. To master this matricakra is a sure way to achieve one's identity with the Supreme consciousness. 'A' is the anuttara. 'Ha' is the anahata. 'A' is the para (highest in the hierarchy of vowels, the subjective world). 'Ha' is the lowest in the list of the consonants (objective world). Bindu is the consciousness of Siva, the potential for manifestation. One can create a cakra(cycle) by uniting the supreme subjectivity (A) with supreme objectivity(ha). The word 'Aham' is one of the most significant conceptual categories in the Spanda Sastras. Aham is the 'self-awareness'. The sense of self-awareness pervades the whole universe.

Matrikas contains five great energies of Siva. These energies are like cakra as these moves in rhythmic cycles. An aspirant who realizes that these cakras are same as Siva, the knowledge of matrika-cakra dawns over him.

In the verse 4 of the Second Awakening in the Siva Sutras, the state of 'khecari' as the stage of realization of Sivahood is mentioned. This is the stage of ananda (bliss) of vast expansion of spiritual consciousness.(Khecari is one that moves in kha or the vast space). This comes after realizing the infinite creative power inherent in the Para-Vak and its manifestation, the matricakra.

First verse of the Third Awakening in the Siva-Sutras mentions 'atma cittam'. This verse itself is a combination of first verse of the First Awakening (caitanyamatma) and first verse of the Second Awakening(cittam mantrah). If two verses are combined, the first verse of the Third Awakening(atma cittam) can be created. The full verse on combination will run as "atma cittam, caitanya mantrah". Since, Kashmir Saivism followed trika structure to unravel the way to achieve liberation in this very life, the three Awakening and three verses are beaded in same structure. It is stated by the commentators that the First Awakening describes the Sambhopaya, the path of Siva to achieve liberation. The second explains the Saktopaya, the path of Sakti and the third Ananopaya, the path of the senses. If the first path is the path of supreme Will (iccha), the second and third corresponds with the path of knowledge(jnana) and action (kriya) respectively.

But, trika philosophy is not concerned with merely understanding triads. There is the turiya, the way to transcend the triads in the world of immanence. This was known as 'catuskoti' in the Vedas. Om has three phonemes,a,u,m& the fourth is the vibration. Similarly, speech is made up of 3 parts, pashyanti, madhyama,

vaikhari and the fourth is the Para-vak. Catusapada has been extensively used in the Kashmiri literature. Therefore, I am of the view that the Kashmir Saivists merely renamed the prevailing idea of catuskoti (3+1) in Buddhist and Vedic philosophy as well as grammar as Trika +1. Even the trident (trishul) represents 3+1 structure. Three prongs a three Saktis, para(supreme), parapara(supreme cum-non-supreme) and apara(non-supreme). But, "paratita" is above the central prong of the trident that represents 'beyond', the Sakti embodying supreme beatitude. I am quite certain that cryptic text of Siva Sutra, structured in Trika way contains the seed of the transcendence by an unnamed fourth. There is hierarchical nesting of the self-similar structure as found in the fractal paradigm of a dynamic universe. While combining the first verses of the First and the Second Awakening, one arrives at the fourth of this catuspada/catuskoti structure. In the combination, "Atma cittam, caitanya mantrah", since 'atma cittam' is the first verse of the Third Awakening, "caitanya mantrah" is the fourth, turiya, the beyond. This sums up the emphasis and deep engagement with the sonic nature of the universe, structure of the phoneme and the textuality of the phenomena.

The Third Awakening describes inferior ways to achieve realization, the way of kriya that includes various breathing techniques, visualization and yogic postures. This section expound on the eight energies of Siva manifesting in the phonetic world. Eight vargas of consonants represented by different Saktis is visualized as surrounding the Highest Sakti sitting in the centre of Brahmarandha. These eight matrika mothers have been termed as the Mother of 'beast' in the Siva Sutra since these Saktis govern all differentiated knowledge mediated through linguistic reality. Since the manifest universe has limitations and is bound, it is symbolically addressed as the beast. By the practice and constant japa, the mantras reveal as the Deity themselves. 43rd verse in this part reveals the technique of self-realization through

breathing, while 44th verse concerns with the Kundalini yoga. Mother Kundalini is termed as the pran (energy of life). A yogi repeatedly experience the revealing and concealing aspect of the objective universe. For him, the objective universe is visible as mere grosser manifestation of inner light of consciousness and identical with it. Spanda in the form of Para-vak is the supreme consciousness which once realized fills the seeker with eternal delight. Three methods (upayas) contained in three part of Siva Sutra for self-realization leads the sadhak to the state of anuttara. In this state, unity of the universe and self is realized. Soham(I am That) state pervades consciousness in three states of consciousness. There is experience of indivisibility inside and outside. One finds consciousness as the root of physical universe. Physicality is mere concretization of grosser state of consciousness. This causes dawn of Highest Bliss (Jagdananda).

Spandakarika, the commentary on Siva Sutra contains 51 verses reflecting the manifestation of matrika (50 alphabets plus dot,[bindu]) as the phenomenal universe. The first verse describes the Spanda-Sakti(Shankari) representing unmesa (emergence) and nimesa (absorption) of the Sakti of Siva. Spanda is at the root of experience. Mantras derive their power from the spanda-principle and takes individual to the state of identity with Siva. The last verse states that when the aspirant realizes the spanda-principle, he can control the emergence and dissolution of the samskaras(mental impressions of one's action as stated in karma theory in Indian tradition). One can become the lord of each of the five group of Saktis i.e. iccha(will), kriya(action), jnana(knowledge), chita(consciousness), and ananda(bliss). There is always a rhythmic oscillation in the existence due to the succession(karma). Unmesa and nimesa are the play of evolution (vikasa) and concealment (sankocha). One, who understands spanda-principle, realizes the Supreme Reality, the source of all powers of creation and dissolution of the world.

‘Aham’ and ‘maha’ exist simultaneously. Aham is the perception of phenomenal universe, the first awareness. Its inverse is ‘maha’, the principle of reabsorption, the dissolution. Spanda Sastras present a view of existence where consciousness is primary and the objective universe is mere manifestation, a condensation of consciousness. The pulsation and rhythm is at the root of the existence. The words correspond to the world. Since the whole universe is always dynamic and in ceaseless motion, the sound-principle gets greater attention. Each motion produces sound, audible or inaudible for us. Sound-principle manifest in a hierarchical universe from subtle to gross and constitute the world. The Para-vak is represented within human body in the sushumna nadi (central channel) as the Mother Kundalini and by comprehending matracakra, the cycles of phonemes & their manifestation in the universe; aspirant can move from gross mantra to the source, Para-vak. Para-vak is the successionless (akramic) soundless sound where words and meanings exist as an undifferentiated unity. Realization of that state fills the yogi with eternal delight. Yogi realizes that the world is not illusion (maya), but real and manifestation of the spanda-principle. World is a creative play of words. There is no extra-textual reality. The Highest Reality is dynamic, creative, free (svachhanda) and the cause of primordial a-temporal vibration. Through mastery over sound (mantra), the Highest principle can be realized and one can attain the creative and blissful svachhanda power of Param-Siva.

Spanda-Sastras are unique texts that combine the best principles of grammar, linguistics, subtle energies, subjective experiences, human anatomy, physiology, psychology, philosophy and traditions. Spanda doctrine situates individual in the cosmic hierarchy and delineates the way to realize the Supreme consciousness. Retrieving the genealogy of certain elements of the Spanda doctrine is necessary to appreciate this jouissance (rasa) of

multiple Indian & Asian traditions which were colliding, fusing and parting during this landmark period.

Rajovada of Vedas & Spanda

The Nasadiya sutra of the Rig Veda contains the vedic doctrine of cosmogony which contains the seeds of many of the ideas of the spanda Sastra. "Sat" is the physical existence while ‘asat’ is the Prana. The sat is born from the asat (Rig Veda. 10.72.2-3). Asat and "sat" have their existence in the Absolute Brahman called Parama Vyoma (RV. 10.5.7). Asat and sat interact in mutual conjunction as Bull-Cow (Father & Mother Principles of Creativity). Asat is the feminine Principle, Aditi. Sat is the male-Principle. Vak (speech) is an attribute of Vyoma. Param Vyoma is the Akshara (alphabet), imperishable Absolute. One can notice the parallel thought in the Spanda-principle where ParamSiva is the Absolute Consciousness. The dynamic vibration principle is the feminine Shakti and the existence principle is masculine Shiva. In the matricakra system, the two principles conjoin. This is the source of emergent creativity in the Universe.

The Vedas conceived ‘rajas’ as the primordial movement of existence that is the source of creativity. It is visible to human beings in the form of the dust particle (rajamsi) which is always in vibratory motion and clearly visible in the light rays. Rajas is responsible for rhythmic movement in the Universe. When opposite poles of rajas (light/darkness; day/light) are created; an oscillatory movement ensues between the two poles. The Pranapana Sutra (Rig-Veda sutra 6. 44-64,) mentions the twin forces of Rajas as Prana and apana (expansion and contraction), vridhhi and hrassa (growth and decay), udaya and Pralaya (manifestation and dissolution); Udagrabha and Nigrabha (ascent and descent) of a cakra. The cosmic rhythm of

Rajas is manifested as in-breath and out-breath like the rays emitted from a pulsating centre. This underlying rhythm of life and cosmos is termed udgitha (Udgitha Sutra, Sutra 7, 65-75) which is a cyclic oscillatory movement (praartate chakramidam sadaiva). At every level of the universe, pranic vibration unfolds through this bifurcation and rhythmic motion in the universe. Chhandas, the rhythm is omnipresent. The unmesa and nimesa (opening and closing of the eye-lids), uchchavasa and nishvasa (in breath/ out-breath) in the two nostrils testify to the rhythmic structure of the universe.

It is apparent that the ideas of primordial a-temporal vibration, rhythm of Spanda Sastras have their earlier roots in the Rajo-vada doctrine in the Rig Veda.

The Satpatha Brahmins propose the doctrine of the five eggs, Panch-anda Vidya. Whenever there is a creative manifestation, there exists the Anda – principle (Egg-principle). The Five Eggs in the Vedic texts are named, Retonda, Mukhyanda, yasonda, Poshanda, Praranda. Prithvi corresponds to Mukhyanda (material manifestation). Surya corresponds to yasonda. Out of Surya principle, Vijnana (Higher) is created. Chandra corresponds to Retonda. Vayu corresponds to Poshanda. It is Vayu that links earlier three viz. earth, sun and lunar spheres. Higher than Vijnana (Surya) is ‘Ananda’ which is eternal and the ultimate end of all creation.

The Kashmir Saivites modified the egg-principle of veda to incorporate in their own doctrine. Abhinavagupta discussed the Andacatustaya, four Andas, in the cosmic scheme of evolution viz. Saktyanda, Mayanda, Praktyanda, Prthvyanda. Saktyanda holds the other three in womb and is the basis of all. Incorporation of 4-egg principle in the doctrine might have been done as a correspondence to the catusyapad structure (3+1) that recurs in

each aspect and hierarchy of cosmic evolution in Kashmir Saivism.

I feel the ‘Spanda’ doctrine itself seems to be an improvement over Vedic cosmogony. Spanda too denotes an egg-principle which is higher than even Ananda. Spanda contains the seeds of cosmic manifestation and holds all other eggs in its womb.

Gaudapada, Sankaracarya and Spanda doctrine

Natalia Isayeva has done an extremely interesting study on influence of Gaudapada and Bhartrhari on Kashmir Shaivism in the book, From Early Vedanta to Kashmir Shaivism (SUNY, 1995) and concluded that Gaudapada, the grand teacher of Sankaracarya should be regarded as “predecessors of certain schools of non-dualistic Kashmir Saivism. Gaudapada upheld the creative and dynamic nature of the Reality that leads to the emergence of a structured universe. He even seems to be the link who adopted Buddhist ideas in the Vedanta and developed the doctrine of ‘Ajativada’ (no-origination). Gaudapada unified dynamic spanda doctrine found in the Vedas with Vijnana doctrine of Buddhism in his commentary on Mandukya upanishad, Mandukya Karika. It is plausible that many of the Buddhist ideas like Apoha (discrimination), primacy of consciousness and sunyavada crept into the non-dual schools of Kashmir Saivism through Gaudapada who had a substantial influence over Sankara’s Advaita philosophy.

It is interesting to note that the terms ‘Spanda’ recurs throughout in the Mandukya-karika. 48th, 49th, 51st and 72nd verse of IVth Chapter (Alatasanti-Prakerana) discusses the ‘Spanda’ principle. Gaudapada describes the appearance of phenomena when vigyana (consciousness) is in spanda. 72nd verse aptly describes Spanda-

principle. The duality of subject and object is mere creation of spanda-principle in consciousness.

Gaudapada discusses elaborately on nature of consciousness in the first chapter, Agama-Prakarana and reiterates the four-pada principle in describing various avastha of consciousness that leads to ultimate liberation. The first three states are wakefulness, dreaming, and deep sleep while the 4th is unnamed, without attribute, mere number four, turiya. This fourth state is the state of advaita, the non-duality. It is symbolized by a dot, bindu, in the phonetic system. Gaudapada put Om as having four-fold structure (catusya-pada) signifying Brahman. Since, Sankaracarya (788-820 A.D.) visited Kashmir, and is credited with rolling back Buddhism in India by appropriating Buddhist categories in Vedanta, his influence over sprouting of non-Dual school of Saivism in Kashmir is likely to be significant. Most of the writers try to show difference between Sankara's Vedanta and non-Dual Kashmir Saivism by pitting the Highest principle, Brahman as inactive in Advaita Vedanta while Anuttara as dynamic, svatantra, self-aware and creative. This is a misconception created by western commentators. We have seen how the root of dynamic and creative First principle can be traced as far as in the Rajovada doctrine of Vedas. Even the term 'spanda' was liberally used by the founder of Advaita Vedanta, Gaudapada in his Mandukya-karikas.

Some try to drive a wedge between even Gaudapada and Sankara on the nature of Brahman. But, Sankara attributes vibration as well as light as the aspects of Brahman. The idea of vimarsha and prakasha in Spanda school reiterates Sankara's espousal. Verse 39 of Brahma –Sutra mentions 'kampnat' (vibration) as verily Brahman and verse 40 is devoted to Light aspect of Brahman (Jyotidarshanat). Sankara has written extensive commentary on the Brahma-Sutras and it is in this very commentary that he propounds the concept of

Non-duality in Vedanta philosophy. Sankara frequently mentions that the way to liberation lies in meditating on 'OM' which Mandukya Upanishad states to be Brahman itself. Om is called udgitha in the Vedas and Brahman, the Highest non-dual Absolute is often eulogized as 'udgitha'. Udgitha in the Vedas connote the underlying cosmic rhythm, the expansion and contraction, a cakra-movement. The dynamic nature of Brahman and the ceaseless rhythmic and ordered creativity is ascribed as the nature of Brahman in the Advaita Vedanta as much as in non-Dualist Kashmir Saivism. It is not merely a coincidence that the very first verse of the Mandukya Upanishad mentions letter Om as everything. Whatsoever exists in time (past, present, future) or beyond time is also verily Om. Both Gaudapada as well as Sankara wrote commentaries on this short Upanishad. What a better example to reveal the commonality of two traditions than the importance attached to SriVidya in both schools.

Science and Spanda: Road Ahead

As discussed in the beginning of the article, there is a race for dominance of two paradigms. Spanda Sastra is a doctrine where the two conflicting paradigm can attain synthesis. The sonic nature of universe is getting unraveled at an amazing pace. There is sound in very motion at every scale. Our senses can hear only a short range of sound (between 20 Hz. to 20,000 Hz.). What is not audible to us is audible sound for other species. While elephant can listen lower frequency sound (below 20 Hz. in the range of infrasound) than us, bats can hear ultra sound. Dr. Valdimir Gavreau, a French robotic engineer built a huge instrument that emitted infrasound between 3 & 7 Hz. The whole building where the experiment was being conducted began to shake abruptly. He and his team experienced violent shaking of their body cavities and they felt ill for weeks afterward. Infrasound can cause permanent damage to various organs of our bodies. Our organs have different resonant frequencies. Our eyes can

vibrate at 16 Hz. That may cause inner visualization or phantom seeing. The full body vibration can occur at 2 Hz. Japa of mantras does produce low frequency sound causing physiological effect over body. Body organs can begin to tremble and shake if the resonant frequencies of organs are continually produced. A practitioner can vouchsafe efficacy of Omkara Japa that may induce full body trembling. Words are therefore not merely sounds. Words and sounds affect our body and mind. Lower the vibration, lower is the frequency and greater is the intensity of effect over our physiology. One can imagine the effect of nada/Para- vak, which correspond to Spanda, a-temporal vibration over our body and mind. The growing field of bio-resonance will open up the vista to decipher the connections between vak and material world.

Scientists have found a correlation between warm touch and release of the hormone, oxytocin. Oxytocin is produced in body when a sucking toddler stimulates nipples that send signal to brain and muscles activate secreting breast milk. During labour pain, oxytocin is produced that induces rhythmic pulsation of muscles and delivery of the body. During orgasm, the amount of oxytocin in blood is found to be higher. Oxytocin causes erection in rats. It can be seen that oxytocin induces rhythmic pulsation of muscles that causes thrust movement and helps in secretion. Soft kindling is responsible for production of oxytocin. Oxytocin is found to be the root hormone responsible for feeling of love and empathy.

Mantra recitation kindles the brain and may cause secretion of oxytocin. Expansion and contraction of muscles in forehead, unmesa and nimesa of eyelids during deep mantra recitation & contemplation may be caused by secretion of oxytocin. But, rhythmic pulsation of muscles always has a finale in secretion. It is possible that there may be certain internal secretions as described in yogic traditions. Secretions are the rasa. 'Santa rasa' and delight is produced by

prescribed methods of self-awareness which cause kindling and triggers bio-chemical cascade.

But, most interesting developments are still to come. Science will soon be incorporating esoteric concept like kundalini in mathematical formulations. Kundalini in the Spanda Sastra is the presence of Para-vak within human bodies and lies dormant like a snake with three and half-coils in the base of the spinal cord represented as mathematical triangle, again a triad. The Shiva Sutras exhort an aspirant to unfold dormant kundalini so that it reaches the highest point, sahasrara, in the cerebral region. The unfolding is done by either grace of God or guru and constant practice is required.

Now, a team of mathematician has presented a two-dimensional geometry of biological time (Francis Bailly, Giuseppe Longo, Mael Montevil: A 2-Dimensional Geometry of Biological Time, April, 2010, National Centre for Scientific Research, Paris). Time (Kala) the signifier of the succession (krama) has always been represented in single dimension as linear time in physical process. But, it is not sufficient to understand key phenomena of biology since rhythm is ubiquitous in biology and there is no corresponding phenomena measured by physical clock that is based on frequencies along with the linear time.

By incorporating temporality associated with external as well as internal rhythm in biological beings, the team has suggested representation of biological time by a two-dimensional geometry. The rhythm in biological system leads to certain non-changing properties. Mean number of heartbeat or respiration during life time is invariant among mammals where as in pure physical system; it should have been proportional to life-span. These rhythms are not temporal rhythm or cycle as they are self-recurring of which total number is fixed

independently from temporally physical life span. This fact corresponds very closely to spanda as a-temporal vibration, as rhythm not governed by krama (succession) i.e. time. Surprisingly, the geometry of two dimensional biological times produces a "second order helix". But, there is another level of rhythmicity in existence that operates at the level of 'consciousness'. I am certain that three-dimensional time in a three-dimensional space will produce the kundalini like geometrical structure. A-temporal Kundalini contains the power to govern three layers of existence-physical, biological and consciousness. Is it not possible to fuse spanda-principle with physics and mathematics with the tools at mankind's disposal?

Now that, leading inter-disciplinary scientists like Stuart A. Kauffman are propounding the idea of "ceaseless creativity in the natural universe as God" (Reinventing the Sacred: A new view of Science, Reason and Religion, 2007), shouldn't we attempt to fuse the doctrine of ceaseless creativity in the Universe with the ideas of leading-edge scientific thinker of our time? Spanda doctrine that emanated from a complex transaction of concept from various schools of thought and practice holds in its womb coming fusion of sacred and scientific knowledge!

(Niraj Kumar is the student of Nalanada Tradition. His forthcoming work is on *Nalanda Tradition*)



Poetics of Longing into Wholeness

~ Ambika Talwar

*Whispering icons whose eyes
Paeon of hope and despair
Long to awaken, to ascend....*

*Come! Arrive in me, I say
Reveal to me manifestations of renewal*

*Instead, the descent—oneiros
Takes me deeper into the painted
And fading faces of antiquity*

Will I get lost in forms and dust of historia?

*Will I find Poseidon in posters alive as in
dream?*

*Will I walk with Athena in stone
As she breathes life into olive trees--
Gains a city and adoration?*

*Will I sup with Dionysus dancing in mosaic
Not pixels of mini-DV...in crumbling caves
Temples to deities in the dust....?*

*What of Arete and Sophia
When where did we all lose them?*

*In our evolution a movement from
From one technology to another
The anvil of the wordsmith
The furnace a hidden heart
Rhythms of a future memory*

*Do we recreate the same forms
In narratives we think are new?*

*Like a puppet strung
In many directions, I close my eyes*

Who are we?

Where are we going?

Why?

(Ambika Talwar is an author, healer, teacher and an artist and is currently teaching English in Cypress College)

Photo Feature on 'Enigmatic Ladakh'

By Deepak Kaw















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